



East Africa Regional Policy Dialogue on Adaptation Accountability and the Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA). Report

To Cite this report use:

ARIN (2026) *East Africa Regional Policy Dialogue on Adaptation Accountability and the Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA). Report*. Rapporteur: Maria. Nantongo. Nairobi: Africa Research and Impact Network.

Table of Contents

<i>1.0 Executive summary.....</i>	<i>3</i>
<i>2.0 Dialogue overview.....</i>	<i>3</i>
2.1 Background	3
2.2 Participants	4
2.3 Format.....	4
<i>3.0 Key discussion themes.....</i>	<i>5</i>
3.1 How accountability is understood and operationalised	5
3.2 Relevance and feasibility of GGA indicators	7
3.3 Evidence, transparency, and feedback mechanisms	9
<i>4. Region-specific implications and recommendations</i>	<i>11</i>
4.1 Implications for regional adaptation governance	11
4.2 Implications for the GGA process.....	11
4.3 Emerging priorities	12

1.0 Executive summary

The Uganda national policy dialogue on accountable climate change adaptation convened government institutions, Parliament, civil-society organisations, academia, professional networks and private-sector actors to examine how accountability is understood and operationalised within Uganda's adaptation context, assess the relevance and feasibility of Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA) indicators, and identify practical approaches to evidence, transparency and community feedback. The Uganda dialogue generated country-specific evidence and recommendations that will contribute to the East African regional synthesis and learning, while informing Africa's engagement in ongoing global discussions on the development and implementation of the Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA) framework. Participants agreed that accountable adaptation must extend beyond financial reporting and project delivery to include transparent decision-making, clear institutional responsibilities, meaningful community participation, traceable adaptation finance, measurable outcomes and enforceable commitments across the full adaptation cycle. Climate-risk information and early-warning systems emerged as the most urgent GGA priority, given their foundational role in planning and implementing adaptation across agriculture, water, health, infrastructure, ecosystems and livelihoods. The dialogue further emphasised that GGA reporting should combine scientific and administrative data with community knowledge and lived experience, while strengthening local-government capacity, accessible communication, coordinated institutions and feedback mechanisms that result in visible action.

2.0 Dialogue overview

2.1 Background

The Uganda National policy dialogue on accountable adaptation and the Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA) is convened as part of a wider Africa Research and Impact Network (ARIN) initiative to strengthen the policy relevance of evidence on climate-change adaptation accountability. The initiative builds on research undertaken by Accountable Adaptation Fellows, whose work examined how transparency, participation, institutional coordination, feedback mechanisms, financing, and digital systems shape accountability in adaptation planning and implementation across African contexts. While the Fellowship generated valuable empirical evidence, it also revealed a persistent gap between research findings and the regional and global

policy processes through which adaptation priorities, finance, and performance are determined.

The dialogue was therefore important because it created a structured space for policymakers, civil society actors, technical agencies, practitioners, and researchers to assess whether emerging GGA indicators reflect the lived realities, vulnerabilities, and adaptation priorities of Ugandan communities. In particular, it sought to ensure that the measurement of adaptation progress goes beyond reporting on plans, funding, and activities, and instead captures whether adaptation action is transparent, locally responsive, equitable, adequately financed, and accountable to affected communities. The dialogue's insights are intended to inform regional adaptation governance and contribute grounded African perspectives to ongoing global discussions on the development and implementation of GGA indicators.

2.2 Participants

The dialogue brought together a diverse cross-section of actors involved in climate-change adaptation policy, research, implementation, advocacy, and agricultural development in Uganda and the wider East African region. Participants included academic representatives from Makerere University; civil-society and non-governmental organisations working on agricultural advisory services, climate communication, youth engagement, environmental action, natural-resource governance, and climate justice. These included the Uganda Forum for Agricultural Advisory Services (UFAAS), Farm Radio International (FRI), Little Hands Go Green, Climate Action Network, the Environment and Natural Resources Civil Society Organisation (ENR-CSO) Network, Youth Go Green, Green Africa Youth Organisation (GAYO), and The Grain Council of Uganda (TGPU). Government and public-sector representation included officials from the Ministry of Agriculture, Animal Industry and Fisheries (MAAIF); Ministry of Trade, Industry and Cooperatives (MTIC); Ministry of Local Government; Ministry of Water and Environment; Kampala Capital City Authority (KCCA); and the Parliamentary Forum on Climate Change (PAFCC). This mix enabled the dialogue to draw on perspectives from policy formulation, legislative oversight, local government implementation, agricultural systems, community engagement, climate advocacy, research, and youth-led action. It also created an important opportunity to examine adaptation accountability across national, local, institutional, and community levels.

2.3 Format

The dialogue was conducted through a participatory and facilitated format designed to enable both collective reflection and focused discussion. It began with a plenary session on Theme one (How accountability is understood and operationalised) during which participants explored the meaning of accountability in climate-change adaptation, including who should be accountable, to whom, and at what levels of

governance. Participants were subsequently divided into two discussion groups. One group considered Theme two (Relevance and feasibility of Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA) indicators), while the second group discussed Theme three (Evidence, transparency, and feedback mechanisms). The group discussions enabled participants to examine the themes in greater depth, draw on their institutional and practical experience, and identify key concerns, gaps, and recommendations. Group secretaries documented the discussions and later presented the respective group findings to the wider plenary for validation, clarification, and further reflection. Throughout the dialogue, the lead moderator provided direction and guidance to keep discussions focused on the objectives of accountable adaptation and the GGA process. Dr. Maria Nantongo, who also delivered the opening remarks, provided the closing remarks, drawing together the key messages from the discussions and outlining the relevance of the dialogue outcomes for regional and global adaptation policy engagement.

3.0 Key discussion themes

3.1 How accountability is understood and operationalised

Participants defined accountability for climate-change adaptation as a governance obligation that goes beyond financial reporting, project compliance, or completion of planned activities. It requires adaptation actors to make decisions transparently, justify how priorities and resources are selected, fulfil agreed responsibilities, and demonstrate measurable improvements in the resilience and well-being of climate-vulnerable people. Accountability was understood to comprise three connected elements: transparency in decisions, budgets, implementation arrangements and results; answerability by institutions and leaders for their choices; and enforceability where commitments are not met, public resources are misused, or environmental regulations are breached. Participants therefore considered accountability relevant throughout the adaptation cycle: climate-risk assessment, planning, budgeting, project design, implementation, monitoring, evaluation, reporting and learning.

The prevailing view was that adaptation accountability is shared across government, Parliament, local governments, development partners, implementing organisations, civil society, the private sector, researchers and communities. Government was expected to provide political leadership, establish policy and regulatory frameworks, coordinate institutions, allocate resources, enforce environmental standards and ensure that climate commitments produce practical results. Parliament was expected to represent constituencies, scrutinise climate-related budgets, oversee implementation and assess whether adaptation investments are reaching areas and populations facing the greatest risks. Local governments were recognised as the critical interface between national policy and communities, responsible for translating

commitments into local plans, facilitating participation, implementing interventions and monitoring results.

A strong emphasis was placed on downward accountability to communities. Participants argued that communities should not be treated only as beneficiaries, labour providers, or sources of project data. They should influence adaptation decisions from risk and vulnerability assessment through priority setting, project design, resource allocation, implementation, monitoring and evaluation. Community knowledge was considered indispensable because local people understand changing weather patterns, environmental degradation, livelihood risks, coping practices and the feasibility of adaptation options. Participants further stressed that adaptation success should not be measured only through biophysical indicators, such as reduced crop loss or hazard exposure. At household level, resilience is also reflected in the ability to sustain livelihoods, protect income, maintain food security, access health care, educate children and meet basic needs during climate-related shocks.

However, participants identified a gap between this expectation and current practice. Communities are often consulted late in the process and have limited influence over priority setting, project design and resource allocation. These stages are frequently shaped by external project frameworks, funding conditions or institutional priorities. Participants cautioned that consultation becomes extractive when communities do not see how their views influence decisions or when findings are not communicated back to them. Meaningful participation therefore requires clear procedures, accessible information, documented feedback channels and visible institutional responses to community concerns.

Participants also recognised the importance of upward accountability to public institutions, national budget systems, funders and implementing partners. Adaptation finance should be traceable from allocation to expenditure and ultimately to verified outcomes. Institutions should disclose the basis for selecting priority areas and beneficiaries, the amount and destination of resources, implementation progress, monitoring findings and corrective action where results are weak. Nonetheless, participants warned that reporting to funders or treasury systems should not overshadow accountability to communities. A project cannot be considered accountable merely because funds were spent and activities completed; it must show that interventions respond to local priorities and generate tangible resilience outcomes.

Horizontal accountability between ministries, agencies, local governments, civil society, academia, funders and the private sector was equally important. Participants stressed that adaptation cannot remain the responsibility of environmental institutions alone. It must be integrated across agriculture, water, health, infrastructure, urban

development, planning, trade and local government systems. The private sector was expected to reduce environmental harms associated with its operations, invest in climate-smart technologies and support local solutions where business activities contribute to climate risks. Participants proposed a combination of regulatory enforcement and incentives, including tax measures, concessional finance and stronger business cases for climate investment.

The principal barriers identified were fragmented institutional mandates, weak coordination, inadequate role clarity, limited information sharing, insufficient local-government capacity and financing, and poor public access to climate and adaptation information. Political interference, corruption and inconsistent enforcement of wetland, land-use and environmental regulations were also viewed as major threats to accountability.

3.2 Relevance and feasibility of GGA indicators

Participants considered the proposed Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA) indicator areas broadly relevant to East Africa but stressed that their usefulness depends on whether they reflect the region's immediate climate risks, institutional realities and community-defined priorities. Climate-risk information and early-warning systems emerged as the highest priority area. Participants regarded reliable, timely and locally understandable climate information as the foundation for adaptation planning, preparedness and decision-making across all other sectors. Without credible forecasts, risk mapping and early-warning communication, governments, local authorities, farmers, businesses and communities cannot adequately plan for droughts, floods, heat stress, disease outbreaks or other climate-related hazards.

Participants linked climate-risk information directly to the relevance of other GGA areas, particularly food and agriculture, water security, health, ecosystems, infrastructure and livelihoods. In an East African context, climate information was seen as necessary for determining when to plant, which crops or technologies to promote, where to invest in water management, how to prepare for floods and landslides, and how to protect vulnerable households and public infrastructure. Participants therefore viewed GGA indicators not as separate thematic categories, but as an interdependent system in which risk information, planning, implementation, finance, monitoring and learning must reinforce one another.

Adaptation planning and implementation indicators were also considered important, particularly because they provide a basis for assessing whether climate commitments are translated into practical action. However, participants questioned whether existing planning indicators sufficiently capture the quality of participation, the distribution of resources, and the extent to which interventions respond to locally identified priorities. They noted that formal adaptation plans may exist at national or district

level without guaranteeing that communities have participated meaningfully in risk assessment, priority setting, project design or resource allocation. Similarly, an indicator showing that an intervention has been implemented may not demonstrate whether it has reached vulnerable groups, reduced climate risks, strengthened livelihoods or produced lasting results beyond the project period.

The discussion identified two principal areas of misalignment between proposed indicators and local realities. First, climate-risk information may be generated at national level but remain inaccessible, untimely, overly technical or poorly communicated to local users. Participants noted that communities require climate information that is understandable, location-specific and communicated through trusted channels in local languages. Second, planning and implementation indicators can give an impression of progress while overlooking local participation, unequal access to resources and the practical constraints facing local governments and vulnerable populations. Participants therefore cautioned against interpreting the existence of plans, institutions or reports as evidence of effective adaptation.

Participants recognised that Uganda has a foundation of institutional and technical capacity for adaptation monitoring. Relevant public institutions generate climate forecasts, environmental data, disaster-risk information, policy guidance and administrative statistics, while academia, civil-society organisations, development partners and private actors contribute research, project monitoring, financing and policy analysis. However, these capacities are unevenly distributed and often operate through fragmented systems. Data are collected by different institutions for different purposes, with limited interoperability, coordination or feedback to local users. This weakens the ability to generate coherent evidence on adaptation progress across national and sub-national levels.

Practical barriers to implementing GGA indicators included inadequate financing for data collection, community engagement and field monitoring; limited technical capacity at local-government level; fragmented mandates and weak institutional coordination; and logistical difficulty in reaching remote or climate-affected areas. Participants also highlighted consultation fatigue among communities that are repeatedly asked to provide information without receiving feedback or observing changes in policy or programme delivery. This undermines trust, reduces participation and can compromise the quality of community-generated data. Limited public access to climate information, adaptation finance information and programme results further constrains meaningful participation and local accountability.

Participants recommended that the GGA framework incorporate measures that better capture the social and institutional dimensions of adaptation success. These include indicators of meaningful community participation throughout the adaptation cycle; locally defined resilience and well-being outcomes; institutional capacity at local-

government and community levels; equitable inclusion of women, youth, persons with disabilities, refugees and other vulnerable groups; and systematic measurement of climate-related loss and damage. They also recommended greater use of geospatial technologies, remote sensing, satellite data and Geographic Information Systems to strengthen environmental monitoring, assess spatial patterns of vulnerability and track adaptation outcomes.

3.3 Evidence, transparency, and feedback mechanisms

Participants agreed that no single source of evidence is sufficient for assessing adaptation progress. Scientific data, including climate forecasts, environmental monitoring, administrative records, project monitoring data and national statistics, were considered essential for policy formulation, planning, national reporting and comparison of progress across locations. However, participants stressed that these sources must be complemented by community observations, indigenous knowledge and lived experience. Communities often detect changes in rainfall patterns, water availability, soil conditions, pests, floods, ecosystem degradation and livelihood risks before these changes are fully reflected in formal datasets. Their experience is also essential for assessing whether adaptation measures are feasible, accessible and producing benefits at household level.

The preferred approach was therefore a mixed-methods evidence system that combines quantitative and qualitative information. Scientific and administrative data provide technical rigour and comparability, while community-based monitoring and indigenous knowledge provide contextual depth and reveal outcomes that conventional indicators may overlook. Participants cautioned that adaptation assessment should not rely only on biophysical measures, such as reduced exposure to hazards or changes in crop production. It should also assess whether households are better able to sustain livelihoods, maintain food security, protect income, access health care, and recover from climate-related shocks. This requires adaptation reporting systems to include community-defined indicators of resilience and well-being alongside standard technical metrics.

Participants emphasised that community knowledge should be incorporated through genuinely participatory processes rather than one-off consultations or extractive data collection. Information gathered from communities should be linked to clearly defined adaptation indicators, documented through transparent procedures, validated where necessary, and integrated into formal reporting systems. Equally important, communities should receive feedback on how their information was used, what findings emerged, and whether their concerns influenced policy or programme decisions. Participants identified the need to strengthen the capacity of local governments, civil-society organisations, educational institutions and community

structures to collect, interpret and communicate adaptation evidence. This would improve data quality while strengthening local ownership of adaptation monitoring.

In relation to transparency, participants identified several categories of information that should be routinely accessible to communities and other stakeholders. These include adaptation finance and available funding opportunities; criteria for allocating resources and selecting beneficiaries; climate-smart technologies and locally appropriate adaptation practices; disaster-risk information and early-warning messages; adaptation policies, plans and implementation guidelines; and information on ongoing programmes, results and lessons learned. Disclosure should be practical and proportionate: the objective is not to create additional reporting burdens, but to ensure that relevant information reaches those who need it in a timely and understandable form.

Participants noted that the usefulness of transparency depends on how information is communicated. National reports and technical documents alone are insufficient for many local users. Adaptation information should therefore be translated into accessible formats and disseminated through trusted channels, including community radio, schools and other educational institutions, local meetings, faith-based organisations, farmer groups, traders' associations, local councils, posters and other information, education and communication materials. Digital and multimedia platforms were recognised as useful, particularly for younger people and urban populations, but participants stressed that they should complement rather than replace local-language and face-to-face communication channels.

Existing feedback mechanisms include civil-society organisations, umbrella networks, youth groups, faith-based institutions, community associations, local-government structures, stakeholder dialogues, media platforms and social media. These channels can help communities raise concerns and challenge adaptation decisions, but their effectiveness is uneven. Language barriers, unequal access to digital platforms, local norms, weak documentation of complaints and unclear institutional response pathways can limit their usefulness. Participants stressed that communities must know where to raise concerns, who is responsible for responding, and what action will follow.

To close the feedback loop, participants recommended clear reporting structures, assigned institutional responsibilities, measurable response timelines and regular public communication on actions taken. They also proposed stronger use of local climate champions, radio engagement, policy briefs, research dissemination, parliamentary forums, professional networks, multi-stakeholder platforms and umbrella bodies to connect community concerns with decision-makers. GGA reporting should draw systematically on these local feedback mechanisms, ensuring

that reported progress is tested against community experience and that evidence generated at local level informs adaptation planning, implementation and corrective action.

4. Region-specific implications and recommendations

4.1 Implications for regional adaptation governance

The dialogue showed that accountable adaptation in East Africa requires a shift from fragmented project delivery towards coordinated, multi-level governance. Regional and national institutions should treat climate adaptation as a cross-sectoral development responsibility, embedded in agriculture, water, health, infrastructure, urban management, trade, finance and local-government planning. This requires clearer institutional roles, joint planning arrangements, interoperable data systems and regular mechanisms through which national institutions, local governments, civil society, academia, private-sector actors and communities can review implementation progress.

For national governments, the principal implication is that accountability should be institutionalised across the full adaptation cycle: risk assessment, priority setting, budgeting, implementation, monitoring, evaluation and learning. Local governments require predictable financing, technical capacity and logistical support to undertake vulnerability assessments, facilitate meaningful community participation and track locally relevant outcomes. Parliament and other oversight institutions should strengthen scrutiny of adaptation budgets, implementation performance and the distribution of resources to populations and locations facing the highest climate risks.

Regional economic communities and regional climate-governance platforms should support harmonised approaches to climate-risk information, early-warning communication, adaptation data standards and peer learning. However, regional harmonisation should not impose uniform indicators that obscure local realities. It should instead enable countries to report on a common core of adaptation outcomes while retaining nationally and locally defined measures of resilience, vulnerability and well-being.

4.2 Implications for the GGA process

The central message from the dialogue is that the GGA indicator framework should measure not only whether adaptation plans, policies, institutions and projects exist, but whether adaptation action is equitable, locally responsive, adequately financed,

transparently governed and capable of reducing real climate risks. Participants considered climate-risk information and early-warning systems a foundational priority because they underpin decision-making across agriculture, water, health, ecosystems, infrastructure and livelihoods.

The GGA process should therefore give greater emphasis to indicators that capture: meaningful community participation in priority setting, project design and resource allocation; accessibility and practical use of climate information by vulnerable groups; local-government capacity to implement and monitor adaptation; equity in the distribution of adaptation finance and benefits; and tangible livelihood and well-being outcomes. Measures of adaptation success should extend beyond biophysical change or project outputs to include household food security, income stability, access to essential services, protection of livelihoods and the capacity to recover from shocks.

Global reporting arrangements should also recognise the value of mixed evidence systems. Scientific data, administrative records and project monitoring data are necessary, but they should be complemented by community observations, indigenous knowledge and lived experience. Community-generated evidence should be collected through participatory methods, linked to formal indicators, validated appropriately and returned to communities through clear feedback mechanisms. The GGA framework should therefore combine internationally comparable indicators with flexible, context-specific measures that reflect the realities of vulnerable populations.

4.3 Emerging priorities

Strengthen climate-risk information, early warning and local communication systems: Climate-risk information should be timely, location-specific, understandable and communicated in local languages through trusted channels such as community radio, local-government structures, schools, faith-based organisations, farmer groups and other community platforms. Early-warning systems should be linked directly to practical preparedness and adaptation decisions rather than functioning only as technical forecasting systems.

Institutionalise community participation and feedback across the adaptation cycle: Communities should be enabled to influence vulnerability assessment, priority setting, project design, budgeting, implementation, monitoring and evaluation. Adaptation programmes should establish clear feedback channels, assign responsibility for response, communicate response timelines and demonstrate how community concerns affect decisions. This would reduce consultation fatigue, strengthen local ownership and improve the legitimacy of adaptation interventions.

Improve coordination, financing and accountability at local-government level: Governments and development partners should increase support for local-government technical capacity, data collection, monitoring, climate planning and community engagement. This should be accompanied by stronger inter-institutional coordination, transparent adaptation-finance reporting, consistent enforcement of environmental regulations, and the use of GIS, remote sensing and other technologies to monitor environmental change, vulnerability and adaptation outcomes.

ANNEXES: Workshop pictorials



Group Photo of participants



Hon. Christine Kaaya,
Parliamentary Commission on
Climate Change



Group secretaries presenting to the house

